Sarnal. No one would question his valour now: Saif's desperate cries received no reply; instead, enemy swords slashed his face. He died.

It wasn't just his warriors who were falling on the field for the ravens to pick at, a rumour of Akbar's own death had begun to spread. It was a dangerous flow of despair; no battle would hold without its commander. Akbar realized what was happening; he made a charge for the centre, yelling all the while, 'Brave men, come up quickly and dispose of these wretches!'[56]

They recognized his voice. All was not ended.

In fact, Akbar's reappearance seems to have given his men a second wind, and his luck to have confounded the enemy. Mirza Muhammad Husain had been fighting all this while, but now he was injured, and soon he was caught. The battle lost one minute was won the next.

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Akbar set up a makeshift 'court' – a 'couch . . . at the edge of the battle-field'[57] – and the vanquished Mirza was brought to him. Though wounded in the face, Mirza Muhammad Husain was able to speak coherently, even pleasingly. When Raja Birbar, at Akbar's side, asked who had made him captive, the Mirza replied, 'Ingratitude to His Majesty.'[58]

Akbar had declared he would drink the Mirza's blood to avenge Saif's death; instead, perhaps pleased with his abject reply, he treated him rather kindly, giving him water from his own canteen. The good feeling dissipated, however, when the Mirza's milk brother was brought forward. This was the man who had killed Bhagwant Das's brother Bhupat in the cactus-ridden battle of Sarnal. Akbar stabbed him with a spear himself, and had him executed then and there.

As blood flowed for blood under the September sky, most of Akbar's troops were heading away to rest. It had been a hard day's fighting. Only 100-odd men stood around the padishah on his couch. It was one of them who, casting a lazy eye upon the horizon, let out a cry of alarm.

Could it be? An army – no, a swarm! – it looked like 5000 men were advancing upon them. Could it be that Aziz was finally convinced of Akbar's arrival and had left the city to join him? No . . . it was the third and last of Mirza Muhammad Husain's coalition, 'the rebel Ikhtiyar-ul-Mulk'.[59]